Till I Collapse

Written by
Francis Louie Ramoso

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DEDICATION

This book is for the ones who bled in silence.
For the ones who got called crazy for feeling what was real.
For the ones who broke down behind closed doors but still stood up the next day.

To my kids —
Annica, Eira, Euno —
One day you'll read this, and maybe cry.
But I pray you feel the strength in every scar I turned into a sentence.
I didn't have it all.
But I gave everything I had to keep my soul mine — and never let the world own yours.

To the ones who betrayed me —
Thank you.
You became my chapters.
You taught me how to write with truth, not with peace.

To the system that tried to chain me —
This is me breaking free.
This is me standing ***Till I Collapse.***

EPIGRAPH

They prayed I'd kneel.
I prayed I'd rise.
We both got what we asked for.

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

I didn't write this book to be liked.
I wrote it because I was breaking.
Because the world around me — love, family, money, religion, systems —
was choking the life outta me, and the only thing I had left was this pen.

This is not fiction.
This is not cleaned up for your comfort.
It's pain. Regret. Rage.
It's a man trying to figure out if he's the villain, the victim, or just the last one standing.

You'll read things in here that might make you uncomfortable.
Good.
You'll read things I'm not proud of.
That's growth.

To the people I hurt — I see my flaws now.
To the people who hurt me — I survived you.

And to my kids — if you're holding this one day, know this:
I didn't write this from a castle.
I wrote it in a room I could barely breathe in, with nothing but faith that maybe,
just maybe, telling the truth would set us free.

This book isn't the end.
It's the fight before the freedom.
It's me — ***till I collapse.***

— Louie

CHAPTER 1: SILENCE SCREAMING

There's a kind of silence that don't feel peaceful. It's not calm, not healing. It's violent. It's heavy. It presses down on your chest like someone invisible sitting there, daring you to breathe. That's the silence I been living in. Not the absence of noise, but the presence of too much that nobody wants to say.

The room I'm in is small. Four walls, one bed, broken blinds, and a speaker in the corner playing *Till I Collapse* on loop like it's the only thing keeping my heart from stopping. I don't know what day it is. Time doesn't move right in this kind of silence. All I know is the weight in my chest and the burn in my head.

I been screaming inside. Screaming so loud I swear my soul's throat is raw. But out loud? Nothing. Just deep breaths, clenched teeth, and fists that tremble not from weakness, but from everything I gotta hold back.

People say, "Get a job." Like that's the problem. Like a paycheck can fix betrayal, fix being disrespected by the people you built with, fix being a man trying to stay standing with chains on his legs and a knife in his back.

I got a bike in debt. Laundry in debt. Rent creeping up like a thief. But that ain't the worst part. The worst part is I got people who said they loved me — who said they were with me — now playing chess while I'm drowning.

Erica. That name already tastes like bitterness. She smirked when I was hurting. Smiled while I bled truth. I looked her in the eyes and spit bars — not raps, but pain, anger, questions — and she smirked. That smile told me more than words ever could. It said, *"I see you breaking, and I don't care."*

And that's when I knew. I wasn't just hurt. I was hunted. Hunted for my spirit. My sanity. My **reality**.

I'd rather someone rob my wallet, G. Straight up. Take my phone. Jack my bike. Whatever. But don't rob my **reality**. Don't make me question what I know I feel. Don't gaslight me into thinking I'm the villain for reacting to disrespect.

I told her she changed. She told me I was insecure. I told her it felt off. She told me I was tripping. I got angry. She told the world I was toxic.

But what they didn't see was the way she moved. The way she slipped out mentally before she ever packed a bag. The way she stayed long enough to make me dependent — then backed off just enough to leave me starving.

And the worst part? Annica. Our daughter. Two years old. Bright eyes. Whole future ahead of her. And I can't even be the father I wanna be 'cause the world don't let broke men have feelings, or kids, or space to heal. They say, "man up," but when you do, they call you cold. When you break, they say you weak. When you speak, they say you angry.

I'm not angry. I'm exhausted. I'm not broken. I'm bleeding. I'm not toxic. I'm traumatized.

And still, I write.

Because that's all I got. Words. Pages. Truth. And a voice that refuses to stay silent, even when it shakes.

I don't know how this story ends. I don't even know what tomorrow looks like. But I know this page right here? It's real. It's mine. And it's louder than the silence they tried to bury me in.

So if you reading this, know — this ain't a comeback story yet. It's a survival letter. A scream with structure. A warning and a weapon.

And I'm still here. Still standing. Still writing...

...till I collapse.